I Love You, Dad (An Unsent Letter)

By Grace Song

GRACE: Dear Dad, I don't know why I'm writing this letter to you. It's probably because writing is easier than making you sit down with *me* for a serious father-daughter talk, since it's difficult for me to freely display my emotions around you. We discuss politics, religion, and education, but I can't remember ever saying "I love you" and giving you a warm embrace. I guess I thought that getting good grades in school was the best way of expressing my affection. Then, three months ago, you were diagnosed with liver cancer and I didn't know what to say. I've watched you sitting on the couch with a blank stare out the window, trying to conceal your worries and fears.

INTRODUCTION

Asian girls who have emigrated to the West with their families often feel torn between a reluctance to take on traditional roles and guilt over rejecting them . . . between the sense of independence Western society offers and the sense of obligation they feel not only to their parents, but to their parents' cultural values. And even as they strive for independence, they confront a society that often type-casts Asian women as meek and submissive. In I Love You, Dad by Grace Song . . . a young Asian woman tries desperately to put her conflicted feelings down on paper for her dying father.

GRACE: Although we're close, we never had the kind of relationship where I could tell you about a new guy I met, or ask you for advice about problems I was having with close friends. Our relationship revolved around what was going on at school for instance, how many scholarships I could obtain in university. You encouraged me to strive for excellence in all aspects of my life and you always tried your best to give me everything I ever needed or wanted. We've shared good times, aside from the roughest period of my

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

life when our relationship nearly ended.

Looking back I regret the grief I caused you but I hope you realize that the tension between us was largely due to generational differences. I know that my naiveté was a huge factor, but it was the pressure of learning to assimilate into two worlds bringing the mutually exclusive cultures (the East and the West) together- that was so overwhelming.

I didn't think you could understand what I was going through. Listening to your stories, it seemed like you were used to living according to a set of rules that everyone accepted. For instance, in Korea, students woke up bright and early to study and, not surprisingly, their typical day ended the way it began. They just studied more. Unlike our relationship, parents and their children shared the same mindset and methods of discipline, and the kids generally did as they were told. Immigrating to Canada wasn't easy. You set foot on foreign soil and immediately confronted new ideas. As traditional Korean parents you tried to keep your customs (the entire spirit) alive by teaching me the values your parents once taught you. Miscommunication led to confusion, and our relationship turned into a never-ending tug-of-war.

You put so much pressure on me to perform well in school. If my grades slipped the tiniest bit, it was time for you to pull out the "what-is-going-on-in-your-head?" lecture. You never failed to ask if I'd surpassed a smart Jewish boy who went to my school. ("Who got better grades this year, you or him?") And then we talked about my future. I thought that by becoming some big-shot lawyer, I'd be living your dream. You said that law was "in my

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

blood" and went on about my "grandfather who was a great litigation attorney." I was glad that you thought I had the potential to become a successful lawyer, but you exerted so much pressure on me. I retaliated from time to time, yelling, "What if I don't become a lawyer! Will that make me less of a daughter?" But as usual, you ignored my emotional outburst. I usually surrendered, totally exhausted, with a pounding headache. I didn't see the point of arguing when it felt like everything I was saying was going in one ear and out the other.

The curfew you enforced also caused friction between us. My friends would constantly ask, "Why are your parents so strict?" My first reaction was to defend you and Mom. "They're not that bad, they let me stay out later on some nights." Of course that was totally untrue. I was always the first one to go home from a house party or a slumber party. I knew it was natural for parents to worry about their children, but you and Mom were so extreme, and l envied my friends, whose parents gave them more freedom.

Things started to change when I turned fifteen. Determined to break your rules, I was sneaking out of the house and meeting friends at karaoke bars and clubs. I experimented with beer and cigarettes, and started to hang out in predominantly Asian crowds. You forbade me to date because you thought it would distract me from my schoolwork, so I began to date people behind your back.

The guys I usually dated were either school dropouts or guys who were on the verge of failing out. My closest girlfriends were shallow, materialistic,

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

and unmotivated to go to school. For some reason, though, I longed for their company. It was comforting to be in the presence of other young, second-generation Asian kids. They seemed to understand me in ways that you couldn't. When I came home, I wore a mask that concealed my true identity. Upon entering the house, the adventurous and humorous girl would disappear, instantly transforming into a quiet and submissive daughter.

I could see it in your eyes when I turned sixteen. You were worried. I was no longer the daughter you once knew. I had become somebody you barely recognized. To take control of the situation, you would deliver long-winded speeches at dinner table every night (if I were home). You eventually disconnected all the phones in the house, tore up all of my friends' pictures, and made me a prisoner in my own house. I kicked and screamed and spat evil words in your face; still, you didn't flinch. At the time I thought you wanted to make me miserable, when, really, you were saving me from failure.

In my self-absorbed state, I never considered the hardships you endured together so I was happy. You didn't make me pay for groceries, you paid my rent, and I never had to cook my own meals. While you and Mom were busy providing for me, I made you suffer.

I remember the night you told me to get out of the house. Mom cried silently, but refused to interfere, aware that it would probably cause more damage. In the heat of anger, I left home with one backpack slung over my shoulder, and you didn't stop me. Instead, you slipped away into your room, defeated.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

Eventually, Mom found out where I was staying and, in a tired voice, she asked me to come back home. When I did, she burst into tears and told me that 1 was killing you. Every day, she said, you came home and walked straight toward the cupboard where the alcohol was kept. The condition of your liver worsened, but you didn't care. Drinking cased your mind and washed your sorrows away. You didn't say much to me when I came back, but Mom told me that you cried for the first time in a long time while I was gone.

Looking in the mirror, l saw an unhappy girl, fraught with anger, confusion, and guilt. l was headed in the wrong direction, and deep down inside, I knew that you were right. I needed to take control of my future. I needed new friends. I needed to start living for myself and not for others. At twenty-one, I haven't finished growing up, but I'm changing for the better. Aware that all of my actions have consequences, I now know that if I'm not careful, life can easily turn into a reckless roller-coaster ride.

During the last couple of years, since you've been fighting your illness, we've switched roles. Now that you are weaker and more vulnerable, I've taken on some of your responsibilities. I seldom have time to hang out with friends because I'm so busy helping you and Mom buy this or pick up that, but I don't mind. It's my turn to take care of you. Sometimes I feel like the cancer is my fault, and that your drinking was intensified by my wrongdoings, but I've gradually learned to change my perspective. Dwelling on the past is pointless, and right now, I just want to make sure that you're healthy today and tomorrow.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

Thank you for your unconditional love, and for saving me from following the wrong path in life. You never wanted to give up on me, and you have done everything in your power to see me grow up to become a responsible and caring adult.

In the past our struggles drove us apart, but now, our experiences have brought us closer than ever. I will never lose hope in you, Dad, just as you never lost hope in me. I love you.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Grace Song
Book: Yell-OH! Girls
ISBN: 978-0060959449
Publisher: Harper Collins
Date (Month/Year): July 2001

AWARD HISTORY

2008 National Qualifier
KS State Qualifier

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY